

“It’s not business as usual for coveted IIMs this year”.

“Highest salary offer at IIM Ahmedabad Post Graduate Programme in Management for Executives drops to ₹54.8 lakh, the lowest in six years”

Such headlines have dominated the news this year, painting a dismal job market for management graduates. As the placement season wraps up, many B-school graduates are still without their dream jobs. Amidst these challenging times, *Business Today* and Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA) have completed this year’s survey of India’s Best B-schools—the 25th edition overall and the 12th in collaboration with MDRA.

And for the fourth consecutive year, IIM Calcutta has secured the top spot among institutes offering the two-year MBA programme. ISB also retains its leading position in the Executive MBA space, while upGrad and IIM Ahmedabad continue to dominate in edtech and short-term executive programmes, respectively (see the rankings starting page 120).

However, despite the top B-schools retaining their ranks, challenges are mounting. In an

era where digitisation and Gen AI are poised to reshape the corporate sector, B-schools have a crucial role to play in bridging the skills gap. The lacklustre placement outcomes this year are a sign of deeper structural issues. Clearly, there is a shift in the global economic narrative—from protectionist policies aimed at keeping jobs at home, to the disruption caused by Gen AI, and the rise of sunrise sectors like electric vehicles, renewables, and climate-focussed sectors. Start-ups are also challenging the conventional ways of doing business.

“Every company, whether small or large, is capturing vast amounts of data. Analytics has become central to all initiatives that companies are undertaking,” says Prabina Rajib, Director at Birla Institute of Management Technology (BIMTECH).

So far, the industry’s response

has been mixed—some choose to fight aggressively, others are exploring collaborations, while some are simply ignoring the changes. How are B-schools gearing up to address this issue?

THE PLACEMENT CHALLENGE

A recent study by Bank of Baroda’s research unit found that the headcount growth rate fell to 1.5% in FY24, compared to 5.7% in FY23 (see box ‘Hiring Slowdown’). Puneet Arora, Managing Partner at HR services firm Biz Staffing Comrade, says campus placements at both engineering colleges and B-schools have been a cause for concern. “The IT and consulting and even manufacturing companies are getting a little nervous about their ability to forecast with confidence revenue growth and maintain their margins and bottom

THE TOP 5 B-SCHOOLS

- IIM Calcutta retains the top spot for the fourth year in a row
- There is a very close fight between IIM Lucknow and S.P. Jain for second spot

Rank (2024)	Rank (2023)	Institute	Overall Score (1,000)
1	1	Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta	898.4
2	4	Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Lucknow	862.7
3	5	S. P. Jain Institute of Management & Research (SPJIMR)	861.3
4	DNP	Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Kozhikode	851.5
5	6	Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Indore	850.3

NOTE DNP: DID NOT PARTICIPATE SOURCE MDRA